



Q How can I prepare myself for labor and birth?

Approaches to childbirth have changed dramatically over recent decades: nowadays it is considered perfectly acceptable to try different techniques and positions in labor to help you manage pain and stay focused yet relaxed for a positive, calm birth. Practicing different techniques while you are still pregnant can help you feel in control when the time comes.

Physical preparation

Thanks to the pioneering efforts of some childbirth experts (see opposite), it is no longer standard procedure to be confined to a bed during labor. Moving around and staying in an upright position may help to shorten the length of your labor. So it's a good idea to practice safe squats, for example, while pregnant to strengthen your legs and thighs in preparation for birthing standing up. "Labor breathing" is another effective way of helping you to manage the pain of each contraction and keep a positive, relaxed attitude. Practice labor breathing regularly in pregnancy so you feel familiar with the technique once you are in labor.

Mental preparation

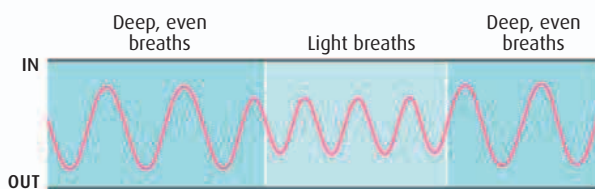
As your body goes into labor, your brain triggers the release of the hormone oxytocin, which increases the contractions of the uterus to ease labor along, and endorphins, which help you feel calmer and can alleviate pain. Staying as relaxed as possible during labor will let these body chemicals work effectively; if you feel scared or fearful, adrenaline, a stress hormone, will flood your body and limit their effects. For some women, techniques such as hypnobirthing, audio-analgesia, visualization (see pp.228–29), meditation, and relaxation will enable an easier labor and birth as well as offering a sense of spiritual well-being.

PATTERNED BREATHING

Consciously changing your breathing patterns as labor progresses helps to force oxygen into your bloodstream so you can stay calm and relaxed enough to handle the pain. Remember, breathing out properly is all-important.

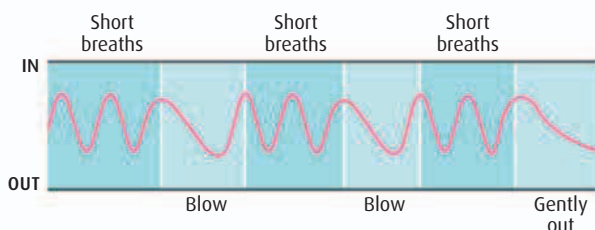
1 Late first stage of labor

During this early stage take deep, slow, even breaths at the start and end of a contraction, and light breaths during its peak.



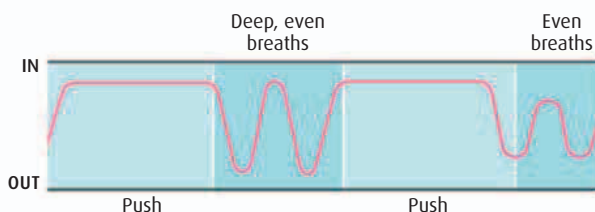
2 Transition stage

As the contractions become intense, and to avoid pushing too early, take shorter breaths in groups of two to three, blowing out each time (see right). Breathe out gently when the contraction ends.



3 Second stage of labor

Take and hold a deep breath while pushing down smoothly. After each push, take deep, even breaths.



Breathing tips

» Start practicing as early in pregnancy as you want, so that you are familiar with all three stages of breathing when you eventually go into labor.

» Inhale calmly through your nose and concentrate on relaxing your muscles. Focus on your out breath: blow out slowly through your mouth and imagine you are exhaling the pain of a contraction. Everyone's pain threshold is different: don't be afraid to ask for medical pain relief if you feel you need it.



Breathing out properly

Hold one hand about 12 in (30 cm) away from your mouth and join your thumb and index finger. You are exhaling properly if you can feel your out breath cooling your fingers. This may help especially with more intense contractions.